

They Mean Business

A little dry humour, lots of sarcasm, with opportunities for one-upmanship and liberal doses of nastiness. From biscuits to colas, from life insurance to a movie rental business, everyone is tuning into spoofs.

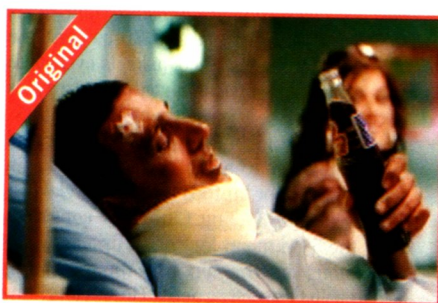
■ By Jhilmil Motihar

Sometime early this year, when Akshay Kumar was giving television junkies an adrenaline rush with his *Bourne Identity*-esque car chase for Thums Up, the boys at JWT, the advertising agency for Pepsi, were thinking of their own little joyride—a spoof on the Thums Up commercial, which they now fondly call the 'uncle' ad because that is what the two youngsters

Both these brands don't do it while taking on competitors but play on a genre. Besides, Parle was launched during the Indian Premier League (IPL) and the cookie's tagline 'short main niptao' fit in with the format of the matches. "The idea worked because reality shows were always on our minds," says Vipin Dhyani, creative director, Everest Brand Solutions, the agency that handles the account. It doesn't hurt that their commercial,

quality, but it certainly has recall value, especially Kapoor's flasher stand-in.

That, at some level, is also the problem. An advertising professional points out what BigFlix has done is actually what advertisers call the first right answer. One chooses whatever comes to mind first and doesn't go beyond the obvious. The real trick is to create a spoof for a product that doesn't necessarily lend itself to humour. The recent Sahara Life Insurance ad



PEPSI ON THUMS UP

Pepsi makes Thums Up taste the thunder by snarkily pulling the plug on the action star's thrill-seeking ad, calling his lookalike 'uncle'



call the fractured Kumar substitute.

That Pepsi decided to take on Thums Up and that Sprite takes on everyone within hitting distance isn't news because this war, on and off air, has been well-documented. But advertisers are now taking the spoof route for everything from wafers to cookies, from movie rentals to life insurance. "Advertisers either use spoofs when they have a great product or when they want to create buzz," says Piyush Pandey, executive chairman and national creative director, O&M.

If Bingo chips spoof the bizarrely dubbed late night tele-shopping commercials, Parle 20-20 cookies make fun of the long-drawn-out process of announcing winners on reality shows.

which plays for at least three months, cost about Rs 50 lakh while a single episode of a reality show costs almost the same.

Getting attention is probably what BigFlix, a movie rental company and portal, also had in mind when they decided to replace Shah Rukh Khan's *Dard-e-Disco* six packs with a paunchy man and to give Ranbir Kapoor's towel dropping scene in *Saawariya* a whole new twist. "The idea is that films have a magical quality and we all emulate them in real life," says Vinayak Upadhyay, senior creative director, Law and Kenneth, adding that they knew the ad had to be funny because if something makes people laugh, only then is there repeat viewership. The ad isn't high on

in which a man challenges Gabbar after getting insurance is a fantastic example. "Who would have thought that life insurance and Gabbar could be in the same ad?" asks Dhyani. And then there are others like the Channel V's *Get Gorgeous 5* campaign which, to promote its model hunt, attacks Set Max's IPL promotion *Manoranjan Ka Baap* with the tagline *Manoranjan Ki Maa Ki*. But considering that the cricket extravaganza really was the father of entertainment, Channel V's purpose wasn't served. "In advertising, creating spoofs is a lazy proposition. It's almost like one is trying too hard," says Anand Halve, co-founder of brand consultancy firm chlorophyll. He explains that since there are multiple channels and